

RAKESH PURI

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A visionary Global Automotive Leader with 32+ years of progressive leadership experience spanning Product Development, Project Management, Battery Electric Vehicle Development, Operations, and Customer Services. Proven track record of building and leading high-performing teams of 250+ across South East Asia (Indonesia, Thailand), Japan (4.5-year Expat with MFTBC), Germany, China, India, and 30+ global markets. Recognised as Asia Lead in Daimler Global Head Groups, spearheading transformational programmes including the Third Generation Battery EV e-Canter (global), Bharat Benz BSIII/IV/VI, King Long Bus, and World Truck. Consistently drives 10–20% cost reduction, organisational excellence, and customer experience transformation.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Daimler India Commercial Vehicles

India

Vice President — Customer Care & Technical Services

2024-07 - Present

- Leads and strategises the national customer care and technical services organisation across India — directing regional managers, workshop operations, and a multi-functional team to deliver industry-leading vehicle uptime and the lowest total cost of ownership (TCO) for commercial vehicle customers
- Champions customer experience (CX) transformation through CXM tools, audit frameworks, and dealer-facing SLA governance; oversees the 24×7 Uptime Command Centre for predictive diagnostics, live support, and DTC resolution
- Builds and mentors a high-performing Centre of Excellence (CoE) for Customer Service Programmes; drives growth in telematics, connected services, remanufacturing, and service contracts for sustainable revenue and margin expansion
- Leads warranty cost containment, analytics-led claims governance within defined TAT, goodwill handling, and retail service excellence enforcement; manages recall campaign readiness and TLMS (ASCENT) documentation
- Collaborates cross-functionally with R&D and CQ teams for post-launch issue closure; aligns regional aftersales priorities with global Daimler strategy and strengthens warranty governance through proactive cost management

Mitsubishi Fuso Truck & Bus Corporation (Daimler AG Group), Japan

Japan

Head of Testing & EV Development — Expat

2020-01 - 2024-06

- Led the global end-to-end development of the 3rd Generation Battery Electric Vehicle (e-Canter) — pioneering HV Battery, Charging Module, Electrical Axle, Battery Management System, and Efficiency Management, with market validation across South East Asia (Indonesia, Thailand) and global markets
- Served as Asia Lead for Daimler's Global Testing Head Group — directed strategic alignment, collaboration, and integration of testing activities across Japan, South East Asia, and international regions
- Directed comprehensive test planning and execution for all vehicle programmes (HDT/MDT/LDT/eSCV/Bus/BEV); oversaw the Durability Bench Testing Lab, prototype building operations, and validation facility compliance and safety
- Built, groomed, and mentored high-performing teams across Asia; fostered a culture of accountability, continuous improvement, and operational excellence; served as key driver of Field Quality Management to secure quality, time, and cost objectives
- Led continuous optimisation of processes, organisational structure, and resource allocation; ensured an environment of high motivation, right mindset, and people development through targeted guidance and training

Daimler India Commercial Vehicles Pvt. Ltd., Chennai

Chennai, India

General Manager — Testing & Prototyping, Product Engineering

2009-09 - 2019-12

- Joined the greenfield project as DGM (Prototype) and promoted to GM in 2012; scaled the organisation from 9 to 250 members and established the R&D test centre, test equipment, and test track (€10M investment) to Daimler International Standards; became a core member of Daimler's Global Team
- Spearheaded testing leadership across South East Asia (Indonesia, Thailand) and 30+ global markets including Kenya, Bangladesh, GCC, Latin America, Australia, UAE, and Israel; led country-specific LHD homologation, validation programmes, and product localisation initiatives

- Led multiple strategic programmes: Project Leader for 37-tonne model, Testing Lead for TF Titan (DICV & Fuso common product), Indonesia market establishment, Euro VI test plan, and BSVI development for all India variants as R&D Team Lead
- Delivered measurable leadership impact: 20% reduction in operational costs, 10% project cost savings, 5% efficiency improvement; successfully launched BSIII, BSIV, and BSVI products in India and export markets within schedule and budget
- Introduced system-based reliability frameworks, root cause analysis methodologies, and communised Daimler global test standards; led product cost reduction workshops and reliability system introduction across the organisation

Tata Motors Limited

Divisional Manager — New Product Introduction & World Truck

Jamshedpur, India

2005-10 - 2009-09

- Led the World Truck programme as Divisional Manager — directed product development process, chassis and cab aggregates development, sourcing coordination, prototype builds, and vehicle assembly manufacturing process establishment for the Prima range
- Headed the Target Cost Realization exercise; conducted strategic product planning and risk analysis for the M&HCV segment; collaborated across R&D, sourcing, and manufacturing to deliver the World Truck and Prima models on time and within cost targets

JCBL Ltd., Chandigarh

Senior Manager — Integral Coach Project

Chandigarh, India

1997-03 - 2005-09

- Headed the integral coach project end-to-end, reporting to the Managing Director; led technology transfer from King Long Automotive Company (China) — drove operations, financial negotiation, troubleshooting, and parts sourcing — and successfully launched the King Long Bus in the Indian market
- Defined product strategy and pricing from development to after-sales service; conducted Homologation tests and secured approvals at ARAI; established the full assembly line, production planning, vehicle costing, tooling development, and parts localisation
- Built and led cross-functional teams post-project; implemented ISO quality systems, inventory management, and incentive schemes; managed new product development on the Swaraj Mazda chassis platform

CORE COMPETENCIES & GLOBAL EXPOSURE

Strategic Leadership:	P&L & Business Strategy, Organisational Transformation
Team Management:	Cross-functional Leadership (250+), Stakeholder Engagement
People Development:	Centre of Excellence (CoE), Change Management & Talent Dev
Product & EV Dev:	Product Dev & Project Mgmt, Battery EVs (BEV/EV)
Technology & CX:	Technology Transfer & Localisation, Aftersales & Customer Experience
Quality & Process:	Warranty Governance & Quality, Process Engineering & Sourcing
Test Engineering:	Testing & Validation (HDT/MDT/BEV), Homologation (ARAI, CIRT, JARI)
Compliance & QA:	BSVI / Euro VI Compliance, Reliability Engineering
R&D:	Prototype Dev & R&D Test Centre
SEA & Asia:	SEA: Indonesia, Thailand, Asia: Japan (Expat), India, China
Middle East & Africa:	GCC, UAE, Israel, Africa: Kenya
Europe & Others:	Europe: Germany, Others: LATAM, Australia, Bangladesh

EDUCATION

Nagpur University, India | 1994

Bachelor of Engineering Industrial Engineering

EARLY CAREER

Industrial Cables (I) Ltd., Punjab — Engineer | Jan 1996 – Mar 1997

Manufacturing and industrial cable operations.

Pam Raffia Ltd., Chandigarh — Engineer | Jun 1994 – Jan 1996

Industrial manufacturing and production operations.